

Pornography, Self-Control & Productivity Among Young Adults

A Cross-Sectional Mediation and Developmental Analysis

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What This Study Asked

Does pornography consumption affect productivity, and if so, how? This study examined four questions:

1. Is pornography consumption correlated with productivity?
2. Does self-control explain this relationship?
3. Does the age of first exposure matter for adult outcomes?
4. Do these patterns differ between men and women?

How the Study Was Conducted

An anonymous online survey was completed by 250 adults aged 18 and above, recruited through multiple platforms across a culturally diverse sample. Participants reported their pornography consumption frequency, self-control, productivity, age of first exposure, and demographic characteristics. Statistical analyses included correlation, bootstrapped mediation analysis, and group comparisons, with a significance level of 0.05.

What Was Found

1. Pornography consumption is linked to lower productivity.

A statistically significant negative correlation was found between pornography consumption and productivity ($r = -0.157$, $p = 0.013$). Higher consumption was associated with lower productivity. However, the effect is small, indicating that pornography is one of many factors influencing productivity.

2. Self-control explains the link.

The mediation analysis showed that pornography consumption does not directly lower productivity. Instead, it reduces self-control, and this reduced self-control is what lowers productivity. Path A (porn $\rightarrow$ self-control) was significant ($\beta = -0.145$, $p < 0.001$), and Path B (self-control $\rightarrow$ productivity) was also significant ($\beta = 1.297$, $p < 0.001$). When self-control was accounted for, the direct effect of pornography on productivity disappeared entirely (direct effect $\beta = 0.032$, $p = 0.681$, n.s.), while the indirect effect through self-control was

significant ($\beta = -0.188$, 95% CI $[-0.287, -0.098]$). This constitutes full mediation and supports ego depletion theory.

In simple terms: Pornography weakens self-control. Self-control drives productivity.

3. Early exposure matters.

Individuals first exposed to pornography before age 18 (74.0% of the sample) reported significantly lower self-control and productivity in adulthood. One-way ANOVA revealed significant differences across exposure groups for both self-control ($F(4, 218) = 4.12$, $p = 0.003$) and productivity ($F(4, 218) = 3.23$, $p = 0.013$). Post-hoc Tukey HSD tests identified the most vulnerable group as those first exposed between 11 and 17 years old, who showed significantly lower self-control than those first exposed at 18–21 years (11–13 vs. 18–21: mean difference = 0.53, $p = 0.003$; 14–17 vs. 18–21: mean difference = 0.48, $p = 0.014$). Notably, age of first exposure did not significantly predict current pornography consumption ($F(4, 214) = 1.52$, $p = 0.198$), suggesting its developmental impact operates primarily through self-regulation rather than consumption frequency. The majority of first exposures were not actively sought; accidental online discovery was the most common pathway (27.2%, $n = 68$).

4. Men consume more, but outcomes are similar across genders.

Males reported significantly higher pornography consumption than females (Male $M = 2.04$, $SD = 1.70$ vs. Female $M = 0.85$, $SD = 1.00$; Mann-Whitney $U = 4512.50$, $p < 0.001$, effect size = 0.41). However, there were no significant gender differences in self-control (Male $M = 3.05$, $SD = 0.77$ vs. Female $M = 3.12$, $SD = 0.75$; Welch's $t = 0.70$, $p = 0.485$) or productivity. (Male $M = 6.28$, $SD = 1.93$ vs. Female $M = 5.94$, $SD = 1.91$; Welch's $t = -1.40$, $p = 0.162$). This challenges the assumption that pornography-related effects are male-specific. The mediation mechanism appears to operate similarly for both genders.

Where to Explore Further

Resource	Description
Full Report	Complete analysis with methodology, all statistical tests, and full discussion
Interactive Dashboard	Visual exploration of the findings via Power BI
Contact	Chukwuka Odey linkedin.com/in/chukwuka-odey chukwukaodey@gmail.com

Thank you for your interest in this research.